

The Handler Project

The First 30 Days

A Day-by-Day Guide to Restoring Food Drive, Loading Markers, and Building Indoor Obedience That Actually Holds

Equipment — What You Need

Simple list. Right tools only.

A flat collar. Tags and daily wear. Not a training tool. Whatever fits your dog.

A six-foot slip lead, thin diameter. Your primary leash once pressure work starts in Week 3. Thinner diameter matters ($\frac{3}{8}$ " preferably) — thick leads dull the signal. One critical rule: slip leads are handler-present tools only. A dog left unattended in a slip lead is a strangulation risk. On for sessions. Off every other time.

A clicker. Any clicker. Cheap is fine. Pick one, use the same one every session, buy a backup so you're never without one.

A raised cot. Not a soft dog bed — a fabric platform on a metal frame with defined, physical edges. Those edges are what make 'place' trainable. A pillow with no boundary is a nightmare. Get the cot. It'll be in your house for the next ten years.

A treat pouch. Clip-on, on your hip. A fanny pack. Anything easily accessible. Reaching into a pocket sixty times a session gets old by Day 3.

Optional but worth having: A 15–20 foot long line for the outdoor work that comes after this program. Flat only — retractables destroy training precision.

What's not on this list: Prong collars, harnesses, head halters, gentle leaders. None of those have a role in what we're doing here. Set them aside. An e-collar will be added down the line, but not in this program. Only after you have this foundation on solid ground.

WEEK 1 · DAYS 1–10

Restoring Food Drive

Food drive isn't a personality trait. It's a switch. Right now yours is probably off. This week we turn it back on.

Day 1 — Your Dog Isn't Picky. Food Just Doesn't Mean Anything Yet.

Today you read. Tomorrow we work.

Don't change a single thing about your dog's routine until morning.

► **Checkpoint to start:** None. You showed up. That's the whole requirement. If it's morning, give yourself the day before we move.

The Real Problem

Your dog isn't complicated. Food didn't stop working. What happened is that food became guaranteed — and the brain stops treating guaranteed things as valuable.

Think about it. The bowl appears twice a day whether your dog showed up hungry or not. Whether they worked for it or ignored you completely. The food was coming regardless. So the brain did what brains do with guaranteed outcomes: it stopped prioritizing it.

There is no such thing as a dog without food drive. Every dog alive needs food to survive. That drive is hardwired. What gets switched off isn't the drive itself — it's the urgency. And urgency is what we train with.

Here's the pattern I see constantly. Puppy eats fine. Six months pass. Dog starts leaving food in the bowl. Owner panics, throws something better on top. Dog eats the topper, ignores the kibble. Owner escalates — better food, richer add-ons, real protein. Dog eats that for a few weeks, then starts leaving that in the bowl too. A year later the owner is convinced their dog has a "sensitive stomach" or "just doesn't like food."

What actually happened: the dog trained the owner. Held out, got a better offer, brain logged it. Hold out again. Better offer. The lesson stacked. Nobody planned it — that's just conditioning. Same mechanism we're about to use to fix it.

Why This Week Sets the Ceiling on Everything Else

Two levers. That's all dog training has.

Reward on one side. Pressure and consequence on the other.

I use both. Balanced trainer, always have been. But here's what almost nobody says out loud: **how much pressure you ever need is directly determined by how much the reward is worth.**

Strong reward value — you barely need correction. The dog is engaged, motivated, working hard. You guide more than you correct.

Weak reward value — you're leaning on pressure just to get basic responses. Not because the dog is difficult. Because there's nothing meaningful on the other side of the scale and pressure is doing all the work.

The most potent reinforcer a dog has is food. Not high-value treats. Not real chicken. Their actual daily meal — the thing their nervous system was designed to pursue. We're not creating a new motivator. We're switching the one that already exists back on.

What you do this week is the ceiling on the rest of this program. Get food drive back and the next twenty days are reward-heavy, light on correction, high engagement. Skip it or half-do it and every day after gets harder than it had to be.

What This Week Is and Isn't

One thing. That's all this week is.

No sits. No clicker. No commands. No obedience of any kind. We are rebuilding your dog's relationship with food. That's the whole job.

I know you want to move faster. Don't.

Every time this program breaks down early, it's because an owner glanced at their dog eating okay and decided the food drive week was probably fine and jumped straight to marker work. The marker doesn't load. The dog doesn't engage. Sessions fall apart. The owner can't figure out why.

The why is they skipped the thing that makes everything else work.

A dog who won't work enthusiastically for their own food — individual pieces, from your hand, rep after rep — cannot be marker trained. No drive, no marker. No marker, no precision. No precision, no training that sticks.

Week 1 is not the warm-up. Week 1 is the job.

What Tomorrow Is Going to Feel Like

One meal a day starting tomorrow. Bowl goes down for ten minutes. If it's not eaten, bowl comes up and they don't see food again for twenty-four hours.

Some of you just tensed reading that. I know. That reaction is the number one reason this protocol fails.

You're going to feel like you're starving your dog. You're not. A dog's biology is built for scarcity and effort — not guaranteed twice-daily meals on a human schedule. Hunger between meals isn't a problem. It's the correct state. It's what makes training possible.

The urge to cave will come. Your dog will look at you. The guilt will feel real. You'll have ten reasons your dog is different. **Hold the line.** Every meal you hold this week is one less correction you ever need later. That's the trade.

Who Can't Run This Standard

Short list. If your dog is on it, modify. If they're not — and most aren't — run it as written.

Visibly underweight. Not slim. Not athletic. Ribs you can see without touching. Hip bones sharp and prominent. Spine showing through the coat as a ridge. Stand over your dog and look down — clear waist behind the ribs, belly tuck visible from the side, ribs findable with light pressure but not visible at rest. That's healthy weight. If you're seeing bone without contact, that's underweight. Those dogs need calorie support during any transition.

Diagnosed medical conditions with active vet protocols. Diabetes, Addison's, kidney disease, post-surgical feeding instructions tied to a specific condition. Real diagnoses with real requirements. I'm not telling you to override a treatment plan.

"My vet said twice a day" is not a medical condition. It's a default recommendation handed to every client. If there's no specific diagnosis behind it, that's advice — not a prescription. Know the difference.

Puppies under ten months. Two meals, softened version. Ten-minute window, food up if untouched, next attempt at the next scheduled meal — not twenty-four hours out. Full protocol after ten months.

Everyone else starts tomorrow.

✓ Checkpoint

One question before bed: can you let your dog skip a meal without caving?

Yes — you're ready. Unsure — read this again and get your household aligned. If someone else feeds the dog, that conversation happens tonight. No — come back when you are. This doesn't work around a handler who breaks at hour twenty-three.

Tomorrow: One meal. Ten minutes. Bowl comes up regardless of what happened. We start.

Day 2 — One Meal. Ten Minutes. Everything Else Goes Away.

One change today. How often your dog eats.

Get this right and everything after it works. Get it wrong and you're building on nothing.

► **Checkpoint to start:** Day 1 read. Everyone who is in the house or feeds the dog knows the rules. You can hold a refusal. If any of that's still shaky — fix it before the bowl goes down.

The Protocol

No theory today. Steps.

Step 1 — Find the daily amount. Back of the food bag. Recommended amount for your dog's ideal body weight — not current weight if they're overweight. That's the daily total. One cup twice a day becomes two cups once. Same food. Same calories. One window.

Step 2 — Lock in a time. Morning works well — the daily ration becomes training currency throughout the day. Evening is fine. Pick one and hold it. Same time every day, within thirty minutes.

Step 3 — Bowl down. Walk away. Don't hover. Don't watch. Don't stand over them. Put it down and leave the room.

Step 4 — Start a ten-minute timer.

Step 5 — At ten minutes, pick it up. No exceptions. No praise.

- Dog finished it: bowl washed, put away. Same tomorrow.
- Dog ate some: bowl still comes up. Save the remainder for tomorrow or toss it. Nothing else until tomorrow's window.
- Dog didn't touch it: bowl goes out of sight. No food, no treats, no chews, nothing edible until tomorrow. Twenty-four hours.
- No praise. We're not reinforcing a behavior, we're reintroducing drive.

Step 6 — Strip the house. Do this now, before tonight.

Every room. Every free food source:

- Bowl sitting out between meals
- Treat jar on the counter
- Rawhides, bully sticks, yak chews, anything that gets grazed on
- What the kid slips them at the table
- What your partner feeds them when they get the puppy dog eyes
- Cat food the dog has access to
- Anything edible the dog can self-serve

Two states exist for your dog now: working and resting. One calorie source. You control when it appears.

Why the Twenty-Four Hours Matters

Pulling the bowl at ten minutes is a behavioral sequence. You're removing food to reduce refusal. That's the mechanism.

Twenty-four hours is non-negotiable because the consequence has to actually register. Hunger doesn't happen in two hours. Re-offer ninety minutes after a refusal and you've just confirmed to the dog that holding out earns a second shot. You rewarded the refusal. That is the exact opposite of what we're building.

Twenty-four hours is the minimum window before hunger starts doing what we need it to do.

Common Questions

Dog finished the bowl in under a minute. Now what?

Best case. Bowl away, same tomorrow. Watch the next few days for a test refusal — slower approach, sniff and walk. The dog is checking whether food is actually finite now. It is. Hold when it comes.

Dog sniffed the bowl and walked away. Is that a refusal?

Wait the full ten minutes. Some come back. At ten minutes, up it goes regardless. Nothing consumed in ten minutes is a refusal.

What about water?

Untouched. Full access all day. We're controlling food, not water.

Can I use training treats during the day for other work this week?

No. Scarcity is the engine right now. Side treats break it. After Day 10 the daily ration becomes your training currency. This week — one window, one source, nothing else.

✓ Checkpoint

One meal, ten-minute window, all free-food sources gone? Yes — done for today. If you left the treat jar out, if your partner didn't get the message — handle it before bed.

Tomorrow: We meet whichever dog shows up. The one who ate without drama, or the one who just told you this is going to take a few days.

Day 3 — The First Refusal. Or: What If It Goes Fine?

Today splits into two paths. Find yours.

► **Checkpoint to start:** Day 2 ran. Bowl went down for ten minutes. You picked up something empty or something full. The result leads you to your path below.

Path A — Dog Ate the Bowl

Easy track. Most dogs do this day one.

Same protocol today. Same time, same amount, same ten-minute window. Bowl down, walk away, pick it up.

Run this every day until you have **four to five consecutive days of the dog eating immediately** — head down, finished in a few minutes, clean streak. Not three good days with a test on day four. A clean streak. When you have it, we move to hand-feeding.

Skip ahead to Common Questions. Done for today.

Path B — Dog Refused Last Night

Here's today: nothing changes. Same time, same amount, same ten-minute window. They eat — great, back on track and read Path A tomorrow. They don't — bowl up, nothing for twenty-four hours, try again.

The doing is simple. The feeling is hard.

You're going to talk yourself into exceptions between now and tomorrow's meal time. She looked thin. He cried at the bowl. One piece won't reset anything.

Here's what one piece does: dog refuses bowl, owner gives something better, dog eats it. Owner thinks the dog is just picky about food. **What actually happened is the dog ran a clean reinforcement sequence on you.** They held out, got a better outcome, brain logged it. Hold out again. That lesson stacks fast. You just paid your dog to refuse food.

Today is when that trap springs hardest. First refusal, your resolve is supposedly high but the dog is right in front of you. Don't let it win.

Why the Biology Is on Your Side

Inside your dog right now, something is shifting.

The systems that regulate hunger are starting to register that food isn't guaranteed anymore. Appetite hormones are ramping up. The brain is recalibrating what food is worth.

This is not deprivation. This is restoration. Wild dogs are hungry between hunts. That hunger is what makes them hunt. Hunger is function, not suffering. A healthy dog skipping a meal — or two or three — is not in distress. They're in the process of rebuilding a relationship with food that years of guaranteed bowls eroded.

Most dogs eat within three to five days of starting this. The ones who hold out longer are usually dogs whose owners caved somewhere in the past and the brain learned that holding out pays off eventually. We're uninstalling that prior learning. It just takes a few extra days.

Hold.

Common Questions

How do I know if something is medically wrong versus just behavioral?

Sick dogs show other signs alongside food refusal — lethargy, vomiting, abnormal stool, weakness, refusing water, hiding, visible distress. A dog who's testing you looks completely normal. Alert, moving around, drinking, interested in everything except the bowl. Normal behavior plus food refusal is behavioral. Hold.

My dog threw up yellow bile this morning.

Small bile vomits on an empty stomach are common and usually harmless. If it's happening every morning for several days, check with your vet. Protocol-friendly fix: set aside a small handful of the daily ration and put it down at what used to be the second meal time as a stomach buffer. Same total food. Same rules apply — ten-minute window, up if not eaten.

My dog is staring at me from across the room with the saddest face I've ever seen.

That's strategy, not sadness. The dog figured out you're the lever and is working it. Get up, leave the room, remove yourself as the target. The dog learns nothing from staring at you except whether staring produces results. Make sure it doesn't.

I caved. Gave them something.

Restart from Day 2 tomorrow. Don't continue from Day 3 and pretend it didn't happen. If you continue forward from a slip, Day 3 becomes the day food appears — and you'll see a refusal every time you hit this point. Reset clean. It costs two days. The alternative costs more.

✓ Checkpoint

Ten-minute window held, bowl up regardless, nothing free handed out from any source? Yes — on protocol. No — if you extended the window, added something to the bowl, or gave anything between meals — reset to Day 2 tomorrow.

Tomorrow: Day 4 is where most handlers break. Not because the dog gets harder — because the handler hits a wall around thirty-six hours and starts negotiating with themselves. Tomorrow we talk about what to do when that moment comes.

Day 4 — Holding the Line When It Gets Uncomfortable

Today is not about your dog. Today is about you.

Specifically: what happens to your resolve around the thirty-six to forty-eight hour mark, and what to do about it.

► **Checkpoint to start:** You're on protocol. Bowl down, ten minutes, bowl up. Path A or Path B from yesterday — doesn't matter. You're here. That's what counts.

The Mindset That Makes This Work

Here's how I run this with every dog that comes through my program.

Food is offered that first evening. Some eat. Some don't. Either way — bowl up at ten minutes. Same thing tomorrow morning. Don't adjust, don't escalate, don't lower the bar. Protocol is protocol.

By day three, almost every dog is eating. The ones who aren't are telling me something useful about their history. Hold either way.

The reason it works is simple: your response doesn't change based on how many days in we are. Day two looks the same as day five. Bowl at the same time, ten minutes, up it goes. No variation, no emotional charge, no negotiation. The dog will eat when they decide to eat. Your job is to be consistent until they do.

The moment your response starts varying based on how uncomfortable you are, you've handed the dog a strategy: hold out longer. They don't plan this. Learning is just learning. If caving at hour thirty-six gets a better outcome, that's when they'll hold out to. Cave at forty-eight next time and now forty-eight is the number. There is no magic number. The number is however long it takes for them to decide to eat — and that decision comes faster when they know there's nothing to wait for.

Environment Check

Today — walk your house and look for failure points.

- Anything edible at dog height?
- Trash can accessible?
- Crumbs under the dining table the dog can sniff out?
- Kid's snack cabinet within reach?
- Cat food?
- A neighbor who hands treats over the fence?
- A bird feeder the dog grazes under outside?

Any of these means the protocol isn't actually running. You're holding the bowl line while the dog sources calories elsewhere. They're not going to learn food is finite if food isn't actually finite.

Check in with whoever else lives in your house. Not accusatory — just clear. "Hey, we're a few days in. Has anyone given them anything? Even one piece resets us." If the answer is yes: don't lecture. "Okay, we can't do that going forward. We restart today." Clean.

Check yourself. This is the uncomfortable one. The number of people who ran a "perfect" protocol and admitted weeks later they'd been slipping the dog pieces here and there — it's a lot. Be honest. If you slipped, restart Day 2 tomorrow. No drama. Just restart.

Why Consistency Is the Active Ingredient

The dog is running tests right now. Not plotting — just doing what dogs do. Try things, observe outcomes, update behavior.

Today's test: will my handler give in if I hold out one more day?

Your answer: no.

The dog who refuses one meal, gets nothing, and eats at the next session has learned the right thing fast — refusal doesn't produce a better outcome. That lesson installs in one or two cycles.

The dogs who hold out longer are usually dogs whose handlers caved at some point in the food relationship history. The brain learned holding out can pay off eventually. We're replacing that. Takes a few more days. That's it.

Every meal you hold this week is one less correction you ever need later.

✓ Checkpoint

Same time, ten-minute window, no extra food, no household slippage? Yes — on track. No — reset to Day 2 tomorrow. Don't continue while pretending you didn't slip.

Tomorrow: By now most dogs are eating. If yours is, we build the streak. If not — we hold. Tomorrow is about what the streak actually needs to look like before we move forward.

Day 5 — The Bowl-Eating Checkpoint

This is the first real gate. You either pass it and move toward hand-feeding, or you stay here until you do.

► **Checkpoint to start:** At least **three full days** on the bowl-feeding protocol. Line held on any refusals. That's the only prerequisite.

What Passing Looks Like

The gate out of bowl-feeding and into hand-feeding is one specific standard. All four of these have to be true:

Immediately upon presentation. Not "after I leave the room." Not "right before the ten-minute timer." When the bowl hits the floor, the dog goes to it.

Finishing it. All of it. Not the good parts. Not most of it.

Within a few minutes. Head down, eating, done. Not grazing through to minute nine.

Four to five consecutive days. Clean streak. Not three solid days followed by a test refusal on day four.

All four. Consecutive. That's the gate.

Common Scenarios at Day 5

Dog eats every time but takes the full ten minutes.

Not there yet. Eating because they have to isn't the same as eating with drive. Stay here a few more days. Most of these flip within another two to three.

Dog has eaten some days and refused others.

Streak isn't clean. Hold the line on refusals and look for four to five consecutive days.

Dog has refused multiple meals in a row.

Hold. Protocol doesn't change. Most dogs in this situation eat by day five or six. Some go longer. A healthy dog is not in danger here.

Dog has eaten enthusiastically every single day since Day 2.

You probably passed this gate already. Read Day 6 tomorrow.

Why We Don't Skip This Gate

Hand-feeding is a harder ask than bowl-feeding. The bowl sits still and makes no demands. Your hand moves, makes eye contact, expects something. A dog who's reluctant about the bowl won't engage with hand-feeding — they'll take one piece and wander off. We need volume. We need consistency. **We need the bowl phase locked before we layer anything on top of it.**

The other thing this gate produces: your confidence. You just ran a multi-day behavioral protocol with consistency in your own home. Most owners have never done that. The reason dogs end up where they are is that nobody has ever held a clear rule for more than a day or two. You held it. That changes something — in you and in how your dog is reading you.

Common Questions

Dog passed all four criteria. Can I start hand-feeding today?

Wait one more day. One extra day of bowl-feeding costs nothing. One underbaked transition into hand-feeding costs more than a day.

Day 7 and still not eating consistently. Something wrong?

Statistically, no. Behaviorally, stubborn dog still running the math. Protocol stays the same. If you hit Day 14 with no consistent eating, that's when to reach out — at that point there may be something specific to your situation worth troubleshooting.

Should I praise the dog when they eat?

No. Not yet. Eating their bowl is just how things work now — not a behavior we're reinforcing. Neutral. Same energy you'd have if they drank water. Praise comes when we're training behaviors. For now, the bowl is just the bowl.

✓ Checkpoint

All four criteria — immediate eating, finishing the bowl, within a few minutes, four to five consecutive days?

Yes: Advance to Day 6 tomorrow.

No: Stay here. Same protocol. Check again tomorrow.

Things to look forward to tomorrow: The bowl goes away. Food comes from your hand. *This is the single biggest shift in the whole first week.*

Day 6 — The First Hand-Feeding Session

Today the bowl disappears. Food comes from your hand now, one piece at a time. This is the day your dog starts learning that you are where everything comes from.

► **Checkpoint to start:** Passed Day 5's gate. Four to five consecutive days of immediate eating. If that's not true, go back to Day 5.

What You're Going to Do

Today's session replaces the bowl meal entirely. Same time. Same total food. Different delivery.

Setup:

- Sit in a chair in the middle of a low-distraction room
- Daily ration in a bowl on a side table next to you — within reach, not on the floor, not on your lap
- Leash on the dog if they tend to wander — step on the end, six feet of slack. Enough to move, not enough to leave
- Nothing interesting in the room. No toys, no other people, no TV

The drill:

1. Take one piece of kibble from the bowl. Hold it in your open palm, palm up, at about waist height.
2. Don't extend it toward the dog. Don't say anything. Don't make sounds. Just hold it.
3. Dog approaches and takes it — that's one rep.
4. Take another piece. Hold it. Wait. Open palm. Repeat.

That's the whole session. You sit, you take one piece at a time, you let the dog come get it. Run this for as long as the dog stays engaged — usually five to fifteen minutes on day one.

If the dog doesn't take the food:

- Wait the full ten minutes
- If no engagement by minute ten, bowl up — entire portion removed — no food for twenty-four hours, same as a bowl refusal
- Try again tomorrow at meal time

If the dog takes food reluctantly:

- Keep going. Reluctant is workable on day one.
- Same setup tomorrow.
- We want eagerness within two to three days.

If the dog takes food enthusiastically:

- Run the entire daily ration piece by piece from your hand.
- That's today's session. Done.

Why This Is the Most Important Shift in Week 1

Until today, food had nothing to do with you. It came from a bowl, on a schedule, whether you were there or not. No connection between your presence and the food appearing. No reason for the dog to orient toward you around meal time.

Starting today, food only happens because of you. It comes from your hand. You are the source.

That single change rewires the working relationship between you and your dog faster than almost anything else in training. The dog who used to walk past you to get to the bowl starts watching you. The dog who disengaged and went to do their own thing starts orienting toward you, because you're where food comes from now.

This is what engagement actually is. Not a command, not something you demand — a state you build the conditions for. Today is the first day you built those conditions.

Common Questions

Dog took every piece. Ran through the whole bowl in ten minutes. Now what?

Best case Day 6. Same setup tomorrow. We run hand-feeding for at least three to four days before adding anything else on top. Volume of clean reps is the foundation.

Dog took a few pieces and lost interest around minute three.

Two options: slightly over-satiated still, or too much going on in the room. Cut the daily ration by a quarter cup tomorrow and try again. Quieter room if possible.

Dog got mouthy on the second piece — actually caught my hand.

Don't yank away. Close your fist the moment the dog gets grabby, hold the closed fist completely still, and wait. The dog will eventually back off and re-orient. The instant they do — open the hand and give the food. A few reps of this and the dog learns that grabbing closes the food source. We'll drill this formally in Week 2.

Dog took food from my hand but refused when my partner tried.

Normal. Engagement starts handler-specific — the dog learned you are the source. Have your partner run their own first hand-feeding session separately. Dog will pick it up faster the second time because the concept is already there. Just hasn't transferred yet.

✓ Checkpoint

Did your dog take food from your hand for at least the first half of today's session?

Yes — eagerly, finished most or all of it: Advance to Day 7.

Yes — slowly or reluctantly: Workable. Run today's drill again tomorrow before moving forward.

No — refused entirely or backed away: Bowl up, twenty-four hours, repeat today's setup at the next meal. Don't advance until the dog is taking food readily.

Tomorrow: Two more days of hand-feeding to lock the pattern before we put anything else on top. The repetition is deliberate.

Day 7 — Hand-Feeding Consolidation

Today is the same as yesterday. Tomorrow will be the same as today. That's the point.

► **Checkpoint to start:** Yesterday's session ran — dog took food from your hand for at least the first half. If the session crashed early or the dog refused, repeat Day 6.

What You're Going to Do

Same setup. Same chair, bowl on the side table, leash underfoot, same quiet room, same time.

Two additions today:

One — vary where you hold the food. Yesterday, same position every rep. Today, move it around slightly. Right hand, then left, then a little higher, then a little lower. Not dramatic — just small shifts so the dog has to find the food each rep instead of targeting a fixed point.

This starts teaching the dog to track *you* rather than a *location*. Engagement is about orienting toward you. If the food is always in the same spot, they learn to engage with the spot.

Two — watch what the dog does after eating each piece. Don't train it. Don't try to create anything. Just notice.

What you're starting to see, in some dogs as early as Day 7, is a glance up at your face after taking a piece. That's engagement beginning to install. Don't acknowledge it, don't reward it specifically, don't make it a thing. Just notice it and note whether it's increasing.

Why You're Not Allowed to Rush This

Owners get restless on Day 7. Two hand-feeding sessions under their belt and they want to introduce the clicker. They want to see a behavior. They want something that feels like training.

I get it. Don't.

The most reliable way this program breaks between Day 7 and Day 11 is an owner who layers marker work on top of hand-feeding before hand-feeding is actually consolidated. What happens: the dog is still building the food relationship, the click starts happening before there's a stable foundation for it to land on, and the marker loads partially or not at all. Sessions get confusing. The owner troubleshoots the wrong thing.

The boring days are the ones that pay you back the most when actual training starts.

You cannot go too slow on the foundation. The dogs who look clean at Day 30 are usually the ones whose handlers ran an extra day or two of hand-feeding when nothing was forcing them to. The dogs who stall at Day 18 are the ones whose handlers moved to marker work after two sessions of hand-feeding because they were impatient.

Common Questions

My dog is mugging my hand for food. Is that engagement?

No — that's the dog targeting the food directly. Engagement is the dog orienting to you because you're where food comes from. The closed-fist drill from Day 6's Q&A handles this. We'll do it formally next week.

How do I know I'm not over or underfeeding during hand-feeding?

Total daily food equals the bag's recommendation for ideal weight — same total as always, just delivered by hand. Weigh the dog periodically and adjust the ration by a quarter cup based on the trend. Don't adjust on one weigh-in.

Can I start the clicker now?

No. Day 11. The sequence matters: food drive first, hand-feeding second, marker third, behaviors fourth. Skip or compress a step and the next one doesn't load right.

✓ Checkpoint

Dog worked through the hand-feeding session with reasonable engagement — taking pieces, coming back for more? Yes — on track. Session crashed early or dog lost interest halfway — bowl up, twenty-four hours, repeat tomorrow.

Tomorrow: More hand-feeding. Same drill. The rep count is what's building the foundation that Week 2 runs on.

Day 8 — Building Hunger. Not Starving.

Short entry today. Protocol is running. What matters now is understanding the difference between a hungry dog and a starving dog.

► **Checkpoint to start:** Two days of hand-feeding done. Dog is engaging, taking food. If not there yet, go back to Day 6.

What You're Going to Do

Hand-feeding session. Same setup. Whole ration through the hand.

One addition: calibrate your daily food amount today.

Pull out the food bag. Look at the recommended amount for ideal body weight. Then do the physical assessment.

Stand over your dog and look down. You should see a clear waist tucking in behind the ribs — not bulging, not flat across. From the side, a slight upward tuck behind the ribcage. Ribs findable with light pressure, not visible at rest.

- Visible waist, belly tuck, findable-but-not-visible ribs: lean and working. Keep the ration where it is.
 - No visible waist, no tuck, ribs require real pressure to find: overweight. Cut a quarter cup. Re-evaluate in a week.
 - Visible ribs without touching, sharp hip bones, spine showing as a ridge: underweight. Add a quarter cup and flag it — this is the Day 1 medical edge case.
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Hungry Versus Starving

Most pet owners have lost track of this distinction entirely. Here it is:

A hungry dog has an empty stomach, is in normal energy-conservation mode, and is highly motivated to work when food appears. Alert, bright, orienting toward food sources, ready to engage. This is the state we want. It's the state every dog's biology was designed for. It's what makes training possible.

A starving dog has burned through reserves and is breaking down muscle tissue for energy. Lethargic, visibly wasted, weak, uninterested in food because the body has down-regulated past the point of motivation. This is actually harmful. This is what owners are afraid of.

The gap between those two states is weeks of missed meals and significant physical deterioration. You cannot accidentally starve a healthy dog by running this protocol. It is not mechanically possible inside this timeline.

What you *can* do by feeding too much: keep your dog perpetually over-satiated. Never quite hungry. Never really motivated. Drive stays flat. Training stays soft.

Right target: lean weight, mildly hungry between meals, eager when food appears. That's the dog you're building.

Common Questions

How fast should I cut the ration if my dog is overweight?

Quarter cup at a time. Hold for a week. Weigh. Adjust. Don't cut dramatically all at once.

Dog was excited on Days 6 and 7 but seems flatter today.

Check the food amount first. If they're eating into satiation before the session ends, they're slightly over-fed. Cut a quarter cup and see if the energy in sessions picks up.

Does once-a-day feeding stay forever?

That's my recommendation for almost every adult dog. Once-a-day matches their digestive cycle better than twice-a-day. The twice-daily schedule exists for human convenience and pet food marketing — not dog biology.

✓ Checkpoint

Hand-feeding session ran cleanly. You did the body condition assessment and either confirmed the ration or made an incremental adjustment. Yes to both — advance to Day 9. Session crashed — repeat today before moving forward.

Tomorrow: The trainable-dog test. The actual diagnostic that tells us whether you're ready to start building.

Day 9 — The Trainable-Dog Test

Today we find out whether you actually have what Week 2 requires.

► **Checkpoint to start:** At least three days of hand-feeding sessions. Dog has been taking food for the majority of each session. Body condition is being tracked.

What "Trainable" Actually Means

There's a gap between a dog who takes food from your hand and a dog who's trainable with food as a reinforcer.

A dog who takes food from your hand will engage in low-distraction, cooperative conditions. Most dogs reach this within a few days of hand-feeding.

A dog who is *trainable* with food has drive strong enough that food can compete with other things — distractions, novelty, the pull to wander. That's a significantly higher bar. It's also the actual bar we need before marker work, because the marker requires the dog to make choices about orienting to you when other things are available.

Three tests. Run them today.

The Three Tests

Test 1 — The Look-Up

Standard hand-feeding. Take a piece, hold it out palm up, let the dog take it. After they eat it — watch. What do they do?

- Looks up at your face within one to two seconds: pass. Engagement is starting.
- Looks around the room, not at your face: drive is there but you're not specifically on their radar yet. Conditional pass.
- Walks away and disengages: drive isn't strong enough yet. Fail — stay in hand-feeding.

Test 2 — The Closed Fist

Take a piece of kibble. Close your fist around it. Hold the closed fist four to six inches in front of the dog's nose. Don't open it. Don't say anything.

The dog will try to get to the food. Nose, lick, paw, maybe teeth. Do nothing. Hold completely still. Don't open the fist. Don't push the dog away. Don't react. Just hold.

Eventually the dog gives up the direct approach and re-orient. Most commonly they'll back off, maybe sit, and look at your face.

The instant they re-orient and look at your face — open the hand.

- Pivoted within thirty seconds: pass. Drive plus emerging engagement.
- Pivoted but took sixty to ninety seconds: marginal pass. One more day of hand-feeding.
- Gave up and walked away: fail. Drive isn't strong enough to stay in the puzzle.

Test 3 — Mild Distraction

Standard hand-feeding. Take a piece, hold it out. As the dog moves toward it, have someone walk through the room — or drop a wadded piece of paper nearby.

- Notes the distraction, takes the food, re-engages: strong pass. Food is winning.
- Hesitates, then takes the food: conditional pass. Food is barely winning.
- Abandons the food to investigate: fail. Drive isn't there yet.

Why This Test Is Not Optional

Everything in Week 2 breaks if you skip this.

Marker conditioning requires the dog to notice the click when it happens. Indifferent dog means the click goes by unnoticed and the marker never loads.

Free-shaping requires the dog to stay engaged and keep trying when easy answers don't work. A dog who'd rather wander than work a puzzle will not free-shape.

Pass the test and Week 2 flows. Fail it and Week 2 is frustrating for both of you without either of you knowing why.

The honest call now is the kind call. Extra days in hand-feeding cost almost nothing. Advancing before you're ready costs a lot.

Common Questions

Passed two of three but failed the distraction test.

Conditional pass. You can advance but keep distraction levels low when you start marker work. Quietest room in your house. Build distraction tolerance later.

Passed all three on Day 6 already. Can I skip ahead?

You can advance, but still run Days 7–9 as written. The rep volume builds a base that Week 2 runs on even when it feels redundant.

Failed all three.

Stay in hand-feeding. Re-test every two to three days. If you're still failing at Day 14 or 15, there's something specific to troubleshoot — reach out.

✓ Checkpoint

Strong pass on all three: Advance to Day 10.

Conditional pass on most, fail on one: Advance with awareness — low distraction, quiet room.

Failed two or three: Stay in hand-feeding. Re-test in 2-3 days.

Tomorrow: The Week 1 gate. Last major checkpoint before we leave food drive work and step into actual training.

Day 10 — Week 1 Checkpoint: Are You Ready to Train?

This is the gate. Pass it and Week 2 begins. Don't pass it and you stay here until you do.

► **Checkpoint to start:** Days 1–9 complete. At least four days of hand-feeding. Trainable-dog test run yesterday.

The Gate

Five questions. Honest answers. All five need to be yes.

1. Is your dog eating their daily ration immediately, with enthusiasm, every day for the past five-plus days?

Not most days. Every day. Immediate. Enthusiastic.

2. Is your dog taking food eagerly from your hand for the full duration of a hand-feeding session?

Not just the first few pieces. Not half. The whole session.

3. Has your dog been free of any food source other than your hand for the past several days?

No treats, no chews, no scraps, nothing from household members. If anyone slipped them something, the answer is no.

4. Did your dog pass the trainable-dog test?

Hard fail on Test 1 or 2 is **not** passing. Conditional pass on Test 3 is acceptable.

5. Are you genuinely confident — not "I hope so" — that you can hold the food protocol for another twenty days while training layers on top?

This one is about you. If you've been wavering all week, the wavering gets harder when more variables are in play. Be honest.

If You Passed

Move to Day 11 tomorrow.

Here's what you actually did this week: restored your dog's food drive to a functional level. Rebuilt the relationship between them and food from passive to active. Installed the beginning of an engagement default. Held the line through whatever resistance came — from the dog and from yourself.

Most owners never do any of this. You did it in ten days.

Don't let the progress make you sloppy in Week 2. The foundation is in — but it's not load-bearing yet. Two more weeks of consistent work is what makes it load-bearing.

If You Didn't Pass

Stay here.

I know you want to move. You've done a week of real work and you want the next entry to be more interesting.

Resist. The cost of advancing before the gate is passed is that Week 2 falls apart. The marker doesn't load cleanly. Shaping doesn't take. You end up confused and frustrated — blaming the

dog, blaming the program, blaming yourself — when the actual problem is you moved before the foundation was ready.

Three to five more days. Same sessions. Re-test around Day 13. The gate passes when it passes. Put in the time and work now, live with the results for years to come.

Before You Move Forward

Starting in Week 2, the daily ration transitions from one hand-feeding session to being delivered in pieces across multiple training sessions throughout the day. Same total food. Same once-a-day model. Different delivery windows.

Every calorie your dog eats from here through Day 30 comes through work. Marker sessions, shaping sessions, pressure work — food is the paycheck for whatever rep just happened. No work, no food. If the dog shuts down mid-session, training ends, food goes away, twenty-four hour reset re-engages. Same protocol you've been running, just embedded inside a larger training structure.

The bowl is gone. The real work begins.

✓ Checkpoint

Five honest yeses — advance to Day 11. Any no — identify the specific gap, address it, re-check in three to five days.

Tomorrow: The clicker. We start loading the marker that runs the next twenty days. This is where it starts getting interesting.

WEEK 2 · DAYS 11–20

Markers, Engagement, and Three Base Positions

Food drive is restored. Now we load the marker, install engagement as a default, and free-shape the three foundational positions — without a single verbal cue, without pressure, without showing the dog a single thing.

Day 11 — Load the Clicker

Today the clicker becomes something in your dog's brain. The drill is mechanical. The mistake is being sloppy about sequence.

► **Checkpoint to start:** Day 10 gate passed. Dog has restored food drive, takes food eagerly from your hand, showing early eye contact after pieces. If any of that isn't solid, go back to Day 10.

The One Rule That Makes or Breaks This

One non-negotiable. Get it wrong and the marker doesn't load:

Click → pause → reach → pay. That order. Every single rep.

5. Click. One clean click.
6. Pause. Count one-one-thousand in your head. Do not move yet.
7. Reach for food.
8. Deliver it.
9. Hands back to neutral.
10. Click again. Repeat.

What breaks it:

Reaching while clicking. Both hands moving at the same time — one clicking, one already going for the food. The dog reads the hand movement as the predictor. The click becomes noise. It will

never load. The pause after the click is what teaches the dog that the sound is what predicts food — not your hand moving.

Pre-loading food in your fist. Holding a piece ready before you click. Dog smells it before the click happens. The click is just sound that falls between when they noticed the food and when they got it. It doesn't load. Take the food after the click. Every time.

Click → one-one-thousand → reach → pay. If you have to slow yourself down to stay in sequence, do that. Clean mechanics before speed.

Sessions Today

Two sessions. A few hours apart. Five to fifteen minutes each. About a third of the daily ration per session. Don't marathon through the whole ration — attention starts degrading past fifteen minutes and sloppy reps undo clean ones.

Your Three Markers

Pick these now and don't change them.

Terminal marker — one click with the clicker. Behavior is complete, come get paid. This is what we're loading today.

Continuation marker — two rapid clicks. Means: you're right, keep going, paycheck is coming. We load a verbal cue in Week 3 once the clicker is solid.

No-reward marker — "no." For now — don't use "no" at all. Don't let it mean anything yet.

Today only the click matters. Everything else comes later.

Why the Marker Is Not Optional

Dogs have about a 1.25-second window in which they can connect a consequence to a behavior. After that, the connection is lost.

There is no human alive who can get food into a dog's mouth within 1.25 seconds of a behavior happening. By the time you've reached, grabbed a piece, and handed it over — you're at three to four seconds. The window closed.

The click happens the instant the behavior occurs — well inside that window. Once loaded, the click produces the same neurological response as food itself. The actual food can arrive five or ten seconds later. The marker already captured the exact moment.

Think of it as taking a photograph. The photo happens at the exact moment the behavior does. The dog can look at that photo later — when the food arrives — and know precisely what earned it. Without a marker, you're paying with a five-second delay. Outside the window. Nothing connects.

Common Questions

Dog flinched at the first click.

Common. Muffle it — click inside your pocket or wrap the clicker in a sock for the first session. After a few reps where click predicts food, the flinch usually disappears. If your dog stays averse after a full session, switch to a quieter sound — ballpoint pen click works fine. Same principle, softer.

Dog isn't reacting to the click at all.

Normal. The marker isn't loaded yet — that's what these sessions are doing. The click currently means nothing. By end of today and tomorrow's sessions you should start seeing the dog snap toward you at the click, before you've reached for food. That's it loading.

Can I just use "yes" instead of a clicker?

Eventually — that's the continuation marker. But the clicker first because it's mechanically consistent. Same sound every single time. You can't accidentally click louder when you're excited or softer when you're tired. Build the click base, then layer in the verbal.

How many reps to load it?

Some dogs load in fifty to one hundred clean reps. Most take a few hundred across two to three days. Some take longer. Don't rush through - it will only hurt the progress in the end. Don't let impatience win.

✓ Checkpoint

Two sessions, click → pause → reach → pay in clean order throughout? Yes — on track. Found yourself reaching while clicking or pre-loading food — those reps don't count. Clean up the mechanics tomorrow.

Tomorrow: Day two of conditioning plus the test that tells us whether the marker is actually loading.

Day 12 — Marker Conditioning Day Two: The Snap Test

Today we run more reps and find out whether the marker is actually in.

► **Checkpoint to start:** Yesterday's click → pause → reach → pay drill ran cleanly across two sessions. Dog is taking food from your hand reliably. If yesterday's mechanics were sloppy, repeat Day 11 before moving forward.

What You're Going to Do

Two more sessions. Same setup, same drill, same sequence. Run them exactly like yesterday.

The new piece is the test. Run it at the end of today's second session.

The Snap Test:

1. A few pieces of kibble in your pocket after the second session ends.
2. Take the leash off. Let the dog go do whatever they want.
3. Wait until they're doing something other than watching you — sniffing something, lying down, looking out the window.
4. From wherever you are — click once.
5. Watch.

What you want: The dog snaps toward you like something yanked the back of their head. Beeline directly to you, eyes locked, expecting food. Give them a piece. That's a loaded marker.

What you might see instead:

- Dog glances over with mild interest then goes back to what they were doing: loading but not there yet. Another full day of conditioning, re-test tomorrow.
- Dog ignores the click entirely: marker hasn't loaded. Mechanics were probably off — reaching while clicking, or pre-loading food in the hand. Repeat Day 11 with strict attention to sequence.
- Dog looks at you, comes over slowly, waits to see if food appears: conditional pass. One more day gets you there.

Why This Test Matters

We test by clicking when the dog isn't paying attention because that's the exact condition you'll use the marker in real training.

During free-shaping, you're sitting silently while the dog wanders. You're going to click the moment the dog accidentally sits, or lies down, or looks at the place bed. The dog won't be staring at you when it happens. The click has to cut through and pull them to you.

A fully loaded marker does this automatically. The click reaches the brain, the dopamine fires — food is coming — and the body follows. The dog is moving toward you before they've consciously processed why.

A half-loaded marker gets a look and a shrug. Training moves slowly and timing gets fuzzy.

We want the snap. Not the shrug.

Common Questions

Passed the test at the end of session one. Move on?

Test again tomorrow in a different room at a different time. If it passes twice, your marker loaded fast — common with high-drive dogs whose food drive came back strong in Week 1. Run Day 13 for one more consolidation session, then advance to Day 14 with confidence.

Passed in the kitchen, failed in the living room.

Marker hasn't fully generalized across contexts yet. A few conditioning sessions in the room where it's failing and generalization catches up. This is normal early on.

Dog ignored the click completely during the test.

Most likely cause: reaching for food before the click finished, or pre-loading food. The dog learned the hand movement, not the sound. Repeat Day 11 with strict attention to sequence. Click. Stop. Then reach.

✓ Checkpoint

Did the dog pass the Snap Test?

Solid pass: Advance to Day 13.

Conditional pass (slow approach): Repeat today and re-test tomorrow.

Failed: Repeat Day 11 with strict mechanics. Don't advance until the marker is loaded.

Tomorrow: The marker gets its first real job — we use it to install engagement.

Day 13 — Engagement: You Become the Most Important Thing in the Room

Marker loaded. Now we use it to install the state everything else depends on.

► **Checkpoint to start:** Snap Test passed. Dog snaps to you on a cold click. If that's not true yet, go back to Day 12.

What Engagement Actually Is

Can your dog give you their full attention?

Not for a moment. Not just when you have food out. Sustained, voluntary attention while the rest of the world keeps going.

For most dogs coming into this program — honestly, no. They're locked onto the environment. Sounds, smells, movement. You're one input among many, interesting when you have food, largely irrelevant otherwise.

By the end of this week, that flips. You become the default. Not because you demanded it, not because you're controlling them — but because one principle has been installed all the way down:

Everything I want comes through this human.

Food. Movement. Freedom. Access to anything good. All of it. The dog looks to you automatically because looking at you is the path to everything they care about. When something worries them, they look to you. When they want something, they check with you first. When something happens, their eyes find you before they react.

That shift — that reorientation — is worth more than any individual behavior we'll ever teach. A dog with it is trainable in anything. A dog without it isn't really trainable in anything — they're just being managed.

What You're Going to Do

Two sessions, ten to fifteen minutes each. Same setup — chair, leash underfoot, bowl on the side table, clicker ready.

The drill:

1. Sit still. No food in your hand. No talking. Just sit and watch.
2. Wait. Wait until the dog starts to sniff your shoes, paw at you, wander to the end of the leash, stare at you. None of that gets a click.
3. The ***instant*** the dog's eyes make contact with yours — click. Reach. Pay.
4. After they eat, return to neutral. Hands down or in your lap.
5. Dog looks at your face again. Click. Reach. Pay.
6. Repeat.

You're marking and paying eye contact. That's the whole drill. Within a few minutes the dog is staring at you continuously. That's exactly what we want. No praise, no verbal cues, no trying to get their attention so it goes faster. Let them freeshape the eye contact.

Now add the toss-and-reset:

Once the dog is offering eye contact reliably, we don't want them fixed in a static stare. We want them to learn the cycle: engage → get paid → release → re-engage by choice.

7. Dog gives eye contact.
8. Click → reach → pay directly from your hand.
9. Take another piece. Say "get it" and toss it a few feet away.
10. Dog goes to get the tossed piece. Gaze breaks. Good.
11. They eat it. Come back to you.
12. Wait for eye contact again.
13. Click → reach → pay.
14. Repeat step 9-13.

The click-and-pay always comes from the hand — that's what teaches the dog that eye contact equals food from the human. The toss is the reset — a cued release so the dog can voluntarily come back into engagement on their own.

A dog who voluntarily re-engages after being released is a dog who's truly engaged. The choosing is the lesson.

Why This Fixes More Than You Think

Almost every reactive, distractible, "won't listen" dog has the same root problem: their attention defaults to the environment, not the handler.

Engagement work fixes that at the source. We're not trying to block out the world — that's impossible. We're installing you as the default. When something happens, the dog looks to you first. When something worries them, they look to you. When they want to react, they check your face before they do.

A dog with that default doesn't bolt after squirrels the same way. Doesn't react to passing dogs the same way. Doesn't have to be called twice because their attention was already on you.

Every behavioral problem that comes back to "my dog ignores me" is, underneath it, a missing engagement default. You don't fix it by getting better at recalls. You fix it by installing this first.

Common Questions

My dog won't look at me at all. Keeps looking at the door.

Two fixes. Quieter room — find the most boring spot in your house. And lower the bar for now: reward any orientation toward you, even if it's not full eye contact. Once the dog learns that orienting toward you pays, full eye contact follows fast.

My dog is staring at the food in my hand instead of my face.

Hide the food. Bowl behind you or in your pocket. Reach back after the click, take a piece, deliver it, hide your hand again. The dog can't stare at what they can't see. The only visible variable left is your face.

My dog stares at me but won't break gaze for the toss-and-reset.

Make the toss obvious — big arc, lands clearly in their view. If they ignore it, wait. Eventually they look away and that's your chance to click them back into engagement when they re-orient.

My dog only looks at my face for like one second.

That's normal. We're rewarding the engagement, the look itself, not the duration. This will build into sustained eye contact later.

✓ Checkpoint

After two sessions — is your dog voluntarily looking at your face multiple times per minute when you're sitting still and silent? Are they completing the toss-and-reset cycle and re-engaging on their own? **Yes:** advance to Day 14. **No:** run today's drill again until the eye contact and the re-engagement are both happening reliably.

Tomorrow: The closed-fist drill. The lesson that teaches the dog that going directly at what they want doesn't work — going through you does.

Day 14 — The Closed-Fist Drill

Today we install the lesson underneath all impulse control: the direct route is closed. The path runs through the handler.

► **Checkpoint to start:** Yesterday's engagement work ran cleanly. Dog is offering eye contact voluntarily and re-engaging after the toss-reset. If those aren't happening yet, go back to Day 13.

What This Installs

High food drive without engagement isn't what we want. That's a dog who launches at whatever has food in it.

What we want is a dog who sees food in your hand and looks at your face first. Drive plus the understanding that the path to food runs through you, not directly at the food.

The mechanism: close your fist around food, hold it in front of the dog's nose, and wait. The dog tries the direct approach — nose, mouth, paws. None of it works because your fist doesn't open. The dog runs out of direct-route options. The only remaining variable is you. So they try the indirect route — they back off, they look at your face. The fist opens the instant they do.

That loop — direct doesn't work, look at the human does — is the template underneath almost every impulse-control situation you'll ever face. Counter-surfing. Door manners. Reactivity. Recall off prey. They all sit on top of this one principle, extended into higher-stakes contexts.

What You're Going to Do

Two sessions, ten to fifteen minutes each. Same setup.

The drill:

1. Take one piece of kibble. Close your fist around it.
2. Hold the closed fist four to six inches directly in front of the dog's nose, at their natural head level.
3. Say nothing. Don't move. Don't react.
4. Dog engages the fist — sniffing, licking, pawing, possibly biting.
5. Hold completely still. Don't pull away. Don't push the dog. Don't open. Statue.
6. Dog gives up the direct approach and re-orient — backs off, maybe sits, looks at your face.
7. The **instant** they re-orient and look at your face — click, open the fist, let them eat.
8. Reset. Another piece. Repeat.

First few reps may take thirty to sixty seconds each. By rep four or five, the dog starts anticipating — sees the closed fist and immediately offers eye contact. When that happens, click and pay instantly. That's the dog telling you they've got it.

By end of today's two sessions: present the closed fist, dog immediately offers eye contact and waits. That's the goal.

Why This Travels Everywhere

Once this lesson is installed, it shows up in every other context automatically.

The dog who's internalized "direct doesn't work, engage the human does" doesn't lunge at food on the counter — they look at you. Doesn't bolt through a door — they look at you. Doesn't snatch from a kid's hand — they look at you. Doesn't fixate on a passing dog — they look at you.

This drill is one instance of a much bigger principle. When we get to counter-surfing, reactivity, and recall work later, the template is already there. The dog already solved this problem at low stakes. We're extending it into higher-stakes versions of the same lesson.

Common Questions

My dog is actually biting at my hand hard.

Hold completely still. The instinct is to yank away — don't. Yanking teaches the dog that biting moves the obstacle. Your job is to outlast it. The instant the dog gives up and re-orient, the fist opens and they eat. They'll learn within a few reps that biting closes the food source.

My dog won't engage with the fist at all — just walks away.

Either food drive isn't quite where it needs to be (back to hand-feeding), or the room has too much going on. A dog with genuine food drive will engage with a fist that smells like food.

My dog re-oriented but then immediately went back at the fist.

Speed of the click matters here. The instant they re-orient — click and open simultaneously. If you wait too long they go back at the fist before you can pay. In this drill, fast click matters more than the usual pause.

My dog looked at the ground instead of my face when they re-oriented.

Click any re-orientation away from the fist for the first few reps. Once the dog understands that disengaging from the fist is what works, start holding out for actual face contact. Build the standard up gradually.

✓ Checkpoint

By end of today's two sessions — can you present the closed fist and have the dog immediately offer eye contact within five seconds? **Yes:** advance to Day 15. **Mostly but inconsistent:** run today's drill again before moving forward. **No:** more reps needed.

Tomorrow: The first behavior. We start free-shaping positions.

Day 15 — Free-Shape the First Base Position

Today we shape your dog's first command. Without saying the command word. Without showing the dog what to do. The dog figures it out. Your job is to mark it when it happens.

► **Checkpoint to start:** Marker loaded. Engagement solid — dog is offering eye contact voluntarily and completing the toss-reset cycle. Closed-fist drill ran cleanly yesterday. If any of those are shaky, don't run today.

Why We Do It This Way

Something I came back to early in my career and have never let go of:

If you want to be successful training the strongest dogs in the world, make them think it was their idea.

That's the whole principle behind today. The difference between a dog who complies because you asked and a dog who owns the behavior. The first dog does it because you cued it and there's a paycheck available. The second dog does it because somewhere in the early training they figured it out themselves — and now it's part of who they are. That dog is more reliable in every moment that actually matters.

We're not going to teach your dog to sit today. Your dog already knows how to sit — they did it twenty times in the kitchen this morning. What we're doing is letting them discover that sitting near you pays. Without telling them. **Because the moment we tell them, we take the discovery away — and the discovery is the whole point.**

Behavior a dog figures out on their own installs faster and holds deeper than behavior they were shown. Dogs fight hardest for behaviors they believe were their own idea.

What You're Going to Do

Chair, leash underfoot, bowl on the side table, clicker ready. Quiet room.

Be a statue. Hands in your lap. Don't talk. Don't make eye contact. Don't lure, point, or gesture. Don't say a word. Sit there and let the dog work out that something is happening.

Wait. The dog will sniff your shoes. Paw at you. Wander to the end of the leash. Stare at you. Maybe bark. None of that gets a click. You wait.

Eventually the dog will sit. Maybe on purpose. Maybe because they got bored and their butt found the floor. **It does not matter which.**

The instant the butt touches the ground:

1. Click.
2. One-one-thousand.
3. Reach into the bowl, take a piece.
4. Pay the dog directly from your hand.
5. Take a second piece. Say "get it" and toss it a few feet away. Dog gets up to eat it — that's the cued release.
6. Dog eats it, comes back. Hands back in your lap. Statue again.
7. Wait for the next sit. Click, pay direct, second piece "get it" toss. Repeat.

Do not verbally praise, the click is the marker. Repeat this process for ten to fifteen minutes per session. Stop before the dog fatigues or before your mechanics get sloppy — whichever comes first. Ten to twenty-five reps in a good first session. Eight quality reps is fine. Quality over quantity.

What If the Dog Offers Something Other Than Sit?

Your dog doesn't know we planned to shape sit. They're going to offer whatever comes naturally.

For most dogs, sit appears first — it's a comfortable resting position they fall into naturally. For some, down comes before sit. A few offer something else.

Rule for today: pay the first clean position. If your dog offers down before sit — pay the down. We were going to shape down on Day 17 anyway. Your dog just decided to do the curriculum out of order. Let them lead.

If your dog offers something other than a recognizable position — wait for sit, down, or early place-approaching behavior. *We're after foundational positions, not transient movements.*

If fifteen minutes pass and no position is offered — session ends. Bowl up. Try again next session with a slightly cut ration. Most dogs sit within the first five minutes. A few take longer.

The One Thing Most Owners Can't Do

Most people can't actually do this. I'll be straight with you.

Most sit down to free-shape, last ninety seconds, and then start helping. They lean forward. Wiggle a treat. Tap the dog's hindquarters. Say "sit sit sit." And in doing that, they hand the dog the answer instead of letting the dog earn it.

A dog who was shown the answer looks completely different at Day 30 than a dog who figured it out. The dog who earned the discovery has more drive, more confidence, more flexibility in new situations. They walk into something unfamiliar asking *what works here?* instead of waiting for a human to position them.

Free-shaping also hits the brain differently. Self-discovery produces a neurochemical response that getting-shown-the-answer doesn't. The brain worked harder to make the connection and holds it tighter.

The boring stretch in the middle — dog wandering, nothing happening — that's where the most important work is occurring. Sit on your hands. Stay a statue. Let the dog work the puzzle.

Common Questions

How long do I wait if my dog won't sit?

About ten minutes per session. If ten minutes pass with no target behavior, session ends. Food up. Come back a little hungrier next session.

My dog never sits — they went straight to down.

Pay the down. Proceed. Your dog offered down first and you're letting them lead.

My dog tried to leave halfway through and hit the leash.

Be a statue. The leash holds them in the session. They'll come back. The engagement work from Days 13 and 14 should have already made you the most interesting thing in the room — let that do its job.

My dog started offering sits immediately. First session was ten straight reps.

Great. Run the second session. Run Day 16 tomorrow as written before adding anything. Volume of clean reps is what makes this hold in Week 3.

✓ Checkpoint

Did the dog offer a sit — or another base position — during today's sessions and get clicked and paid for it multiple times? **Yes:** advance to Day 16. **No — dog moved around without ever offering a position:** food drive may need one more day. Cut the ration slightly and try again tomorrow. Three sessions with no offered behavior — reach out, there's likely something specific to troubleshoot.

Tomorrow: More reps on the same position. Same drill. The volume is the work.